M365-10 · SharePoint Site Request, Provisioning & Ownership

How a site is created with an owner, a classification and a purpose — so it does not become the thing nobody maintains.

Field	Value
Document ID	M365-10
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	A. Microsoft 365
Operating tier	Tier 3 — Expert Services owns SharePoint architecture; Tier 2 provisions.
Review cycle	Annually.

1. Purpose

SharePoint sites are cheap to create and expensive to leave unowned. This document makes sure that every site starts with somebody accountable for it, a classification that determines its rules, and a purpose that makes it reviewable later.

The cost of not doing that is easy to see. A typical example is a broken-links ticket against the main intranet site that sits open past its service target. Link rot is not difficult to fix — it is difficult to assign, because the content has no owner, so the ticket sits.

2. Three things every site has from the moment it exists

A named owner	A staff member, plus a deputy. Not a department, not IT, and not the person who happened to request it if they are not going to look after it. The owner approves access (M365-11) and confirms membership at review.
A classification	PUBLIC, INTERNAL, CONFIDENTIAL or RESTRICTED, set at creation by the owner under M365-15. Everything in the site inherits it, which is what makes classification workable at all.
A stated purpose	One sentence. It is what makes review possible: at review the question is “is this still true?”, which somebody can answer, rather than “is this site still needed?”, which nobody can.

A site cannot be provisioned without all three. This is the single control that prevents the situation the broken-links ticket represents.

3. Do you need a site?

Asking honestly saves the organization a site it will have to govern for a decade.

You need a site when	You need something else when
A team needs a shared place for documents that outlives any individual.	You want to send mail to a group — that is M365-04.
Content must be permissioned as a set, with an owner.	A department needs one published address several people answer — M365-03.
A department is receiving content from a retiring file share (M365-13).	One person needs to share a few documents — share them from where they are.
A project has documents, a lifespan and a defined membership.	A team wants chat and files together — a Team, which creates a site anyway (M365-07).
Content needs a classification distinct from an existing site (M365-15 §4).	It duplicates an existing site with slightly different membership — that is two half-maintained sites.

4. Requesting one

1. Requested through the service desk with the Appendix A fields. Self-service site creation is disabled, which is what allows §2 to be enforced.
2. Tier 2 checks the request names an owner who is staff, a deputy, a classification and a purpose. Missing any of them, the request goes back — politely, with an explanation of why each is needed.
3. Tier 2 checks it is not duplicating an existing site. Where it nearly is, the better answer is usually access to the existing one.
4. CONFIDENTIAL and RESTRICTED classifications are confirmed by Tier 4 before provisioning (M365-15).
5. Where the site will receive content from a retiring file share, it is created under M365-13 §4.1 with the migration in view.

5. Provisioning

1. Create the site with a name that describes its function, not its current project name or leader. Names outlive both.
2. Set the owner and deputy in Site Owners. Two or three people, never more.
3. Create Site Members and Site Visitors and permission the site through them only (M365-11 §2). No individual grants, from the first day.
4. Apply the sharing configuration for the classification: external sharing off for CONFIDENTIAL and RESTRICTED, anonymous links disabled above INTERNAL (M365-14 §5).
5. Apply the retention policy for the classification (M365-16).
6. Record the site in the site register: URL, owner, deputy, classification, purpose, created date, review date.
7. Send the owner the one-pager at Appendix B. Most owners do not know they have become one, and an owner who does not know is functionally no owner at all.

6. The owner’s job

Deliberately small. An owner role that demands much will be declined or ignored.

- Approve who has access, when asked (M365-11 §4).
- Confirm the membership once a year — five minutes, from a list IT sends.
- Say when the site is no longer needed.
- Nominate a successor before leaving or changing role.
- Keep the content sane: no obligation to curate it, but a broken link somebody reports is the owner’s to fix or to ask IT to fix. That single line is what closes the broken-links ticket.

7. Ownership changes

- Ownership transfers before the outgoing owner loses access, never after (ACC-01 §7.2 step 4).
- On a role change within the organization, the question is asked rather than assumed — a mover frequently keeps ownership of something that belonged to their old job (ACC-01 §6.2).
- Where an owner has left with no successor named, Tier 4 assigns one from the department. IT does not become the owner by default; that is how a site becomes nobody’s.
- An owner who declines the role is a useful signal. Either the site belongs to a different department, or it is no longer needed (§8).

8. Review and closure

1. Annually, Tier 2 sends each owner: the membership, the classification, the stated purpose, and the date of the most recent content change.
2. The owner confirms, corrects, or says it is finished.
3. A site with no content change in two years and an owner who cannot say what it is for is a candidate for closure. Say so plainly and give them a month.
4. Closure means: set read-only, retain per M365-16, remove from active navigation, mark closed in the register. It does not mean delete — a closed site can be reopened; a deleted one produces the phone call nobody wants.
5. A site with no identifiable owner at review goes to Tier 4 as a decision, not to IT as a default.

9. Service levels

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
New site, complete request, INTERNAL	P3 — 2 coverage days.
New site, CONFIDENTIAL or above	P3 — 5 coverage days, allowing for Tier 4 confirmation.
Incomplete request	Returned same day with what is missing and why.
Migration destination site (M365-13)	Tier 3 protected capacity, on the migration schedule.
Ownership transfer	With the ACC-01 leaver or mover procedure.

Request	Commitment (per GOV-06)
Broken content reported on an owned site	P3 — routed to the owner, with IT assisting.

10. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
Site register: URL, owner, deputy, classification, purpose, dates	IT register	Life of the site + 3 years
Request and Tier 4 confirmation where applicable	Ticket	3 years
Annual review confirmations	Ticket	3 years
Ownership transfers	Ticket + register	Life of the site
Closure decisions	Register	7 years

11. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
M365-15	Data Classification & Handling	Classification is assigned here — §2 is what makes that scheme work.
M365-11	SharePoint & OneDrive Permission Management	How the groups created at §5 are then managed.
M365-13	File Share Retirement & Migration Runbook	Creates destinations through this document.
M365-14	External Sharing & Guest Access Governance	Site-level sharing configuration.
M365-16	Retention, Legal Hold & eDiscovery	Retention applied at §5.
M365-07	Teams Provisioning, Naming & Lifecycle	A Team creates a site; the same three things apply.
M365-12	OneDrive Appropriate Use	Sites are where institutional records belong.
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle	Ownership transfer at mover and leaver.
GOV-01	SOP Catalog Governance	The SOP library is itself a site provisioned under this document.

Appendix A — Request fields

Field	Why
Site name	Function, not project name or leader. Names outlive both.

Field	Why
Purpose, one sentence	What makes annual review answerable.
Named owner (staff)	A person. A department cannot approve access.
Named deputy	So the site is not stuck when the owner is on leave.
Classification	PUBLIC / INTERNAL / CONFIDENTIAL / RESTRICTED (M365-15 §4).
Who needs access, and who only needs to read	Members and Visitors from the outset.
External access needed?	Triggers M365-14 rather than being configured later.
Receiving content from a file share?	Links the site to the M365-13 migration.
Expected lifespan	A project site with an end date is easier to close than one without.

Appendix B — Owner's one-pager

Send this at provisioning. Most owners do not know they are one.

You now own a site	You decide who can get into it. IT will do the administration, but will not add anybody without your say-so.
Its classification is	[stated] — which sets the rules on sharing, external access and retention. If that looks wrong, tell us.
To give somebody access	Ask the service desk, naming the person. That way there is a record of who authorised it, which protects you as much as anyone.
Once a year	We will send you the list of people with access and ask you to confirm it. Five minutes, and it is the main thing that stops access accumulating.
If something breaks	A broken link or a missing document on your site is yours to fix or to ask us to fix. Please do ask — that is not an imposition.
Before you leave or change role	Tell us who should take over. A site with no owner stops being maintained and nobody notices until somebody needs it.
When it is finished	Tell us. We will set it read-only and keep the content — closing a site is easy and reopening one is possible.

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.